



Choosing a Name

First impressions count, so consider carefully when deciding on a name for your business. Think about how to make it descriptive, catchy, unique, and, above all, memorable, so you stand out from the competition.

Getting it right

Since your company's name is likely to be the first thing customers note about your business, it is crucial to get it right. Decide whether it should personify what your start-up offers, reflect your values, or capture your brand's personality (see pp.60–61).

Sole proprietors looking to build a personal brand might include their own name and a description of what the business does. Businesses targeting local clients might include their location in the name.

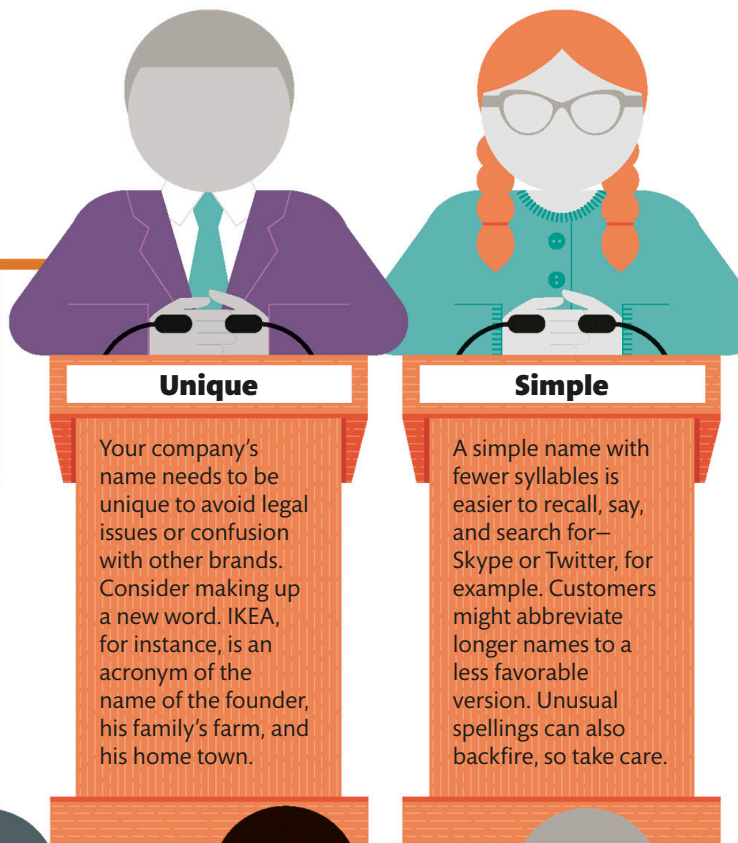
Formal names can convey ideas of reliability and trust but may lack youthful appeal. Your name should be simple, easy to say, and easy to remember. A name that is fun, clever, or humorous may grab attention, but be careful because wordplay may not translate, and you risk your start-up not being taken seriously.

Research your business field to make sure that your preferred name is not already in use. If it is similar to another company's name or trademark (see pp.96–97), you may have to change it—or face a costly lawsuit.



What makes a good name?

The best names are memorable for the right reasons—they are accessible and have positive associations. They should be easy to say, write, and spell, and should be an asset to your business. If you plan to trade internationally, check how your name translates in other languages.



Unique

Your company's name needs to be unique to avoid legal issues or confusion with other brands. Consider making up a new word. IKEA, for instance, is an acronym of the name of the founder, his family's farm, and his home town.

Simple

A simple name with fewer syllables is easier to recall, say, and search for—Skype or Twitter, for example. Customers might abbreviate longer names to a less favorable version. Unusual spellings can also backfire, so take care.

